What Missionary Control Left in the Language of Two 1880s isiXhosa Newspapers

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Abstract

From 1884 the missionary *Isigidimi sama-Xosa* and the African-owned *Imvo Zabantsundu* ran side by side. Did missionary control show in *what* they printed (salience) or *how* they used words (framing)? Imvo was not more political in vocabulary: of ten political concepts fixed in advance, only parliament differs (3.3×, uncorrected). Exploratory religion differs most: Isigidimi uses it four times as often, in readers' letters too. Holding the editor constant, Jabavu's religious vocabulary fell to a third when he left Isigidimi, though changes of editor also moved it. Framing evidence is weak: a religious lean of political words rests on *umhlaba*, used in different senses, and a neutral control leans further. Tokenizers charge 1.7–12% more for this text. Control, alongside the editor, shaped what the papers printed; whether it shaped how they wrote lies below our detection floor.

Introduction and Background

Where did missionary control leave its trace in the language of the earliest isiXhosa press? In the IsiXhosa Intellectual Traditions archive (Schoots et al., 2023a), *Isigidimi sama-Xosa* was a missionary paper; *Imvo Zabantsundu*, founded in 1884 by Isigidimi's former editor J. T. Jabavu, was the first African-owned isiXhosa paper, free "from any missionary control" (Schoots et al., 2023a, p. 55). From late 1884 both had African editors, Gqoba and Jabavu (Schoots, 2023b, p. 71). Comparing the papers contrasts control, but also two editors, places and audiences, which one paper per side cannot separate. So we also hold the editor constant: Jabavu edited Isigidimi in 1881–84, then Imvo.

Communication research separates *agenda-setting*, what a paper covers (McCombs & Shaw, 1972), from *framing*, how it presents it (Entman, 1993). We measure the first as **salience**, how often a topic's words appear, and the second with word embeddings (Hamilton et al., 2016a). Such studies mostly use modern news (Card et al., 2015; Field et al., 2018); Schoots (2023b) counted root words in these papers. We add controls that make both testable, the same-editor contrast, and a letters-versus-rest split to ask *how* control worked; finally, we ask whether this history still shapes how machines read the archive (Petrov et al., 2023; Rust et al., 2021). **H1**: the papers differ in how often they use political and religious words. **H2**: Isigidimi's political words sit closer to religious contexts. **H3**: historical text and its spelling raise tokenizer cost.

Methods

Data. We use the archive's human-corrected transcriptions, not spell-checked (Schoots et al., 2023a, p. 59), from November 1884 to 1888 (Isigidimi's 1886 editions are missing): 286,663 tokens of Isigidimi and 1.31M of Imvo.

Threat	Response
Different years	Nov 1884–1888 only; month-matched draws
Imvo 4.6× larger	Ten Imvo samples of Isigidimi's size
Frequency effects	2000 matched random word sets (Monroe et al., 2008)
Change over time	Each paper's own drift in other years
Unstable embeddings	Tune for seed stability; average ten runs
Non-political effects	Four neutral control concepts
One paper per side	Same editor in both; place, audience unfixed

Table 1: Threats to a fair comparison, and our response.

Salience. Concepts are word stems adapted from Schoots (2023b) (Table S1): ten political concepts fixed in advance, four neutral controls, and religion (*tixo*, *kristu*). Religion is exploratory: the archive's authors expect it (Schoots et al., 2023a, p. 57), but a classifier trained on the same years chose it (logistic regression on shared words, issue-grouped nested cross-validation, 0.83 balanced accuracy). Ratios carry issue-bootstrap CIs; the same-editor contrast uses Isigidimi of January 1881 to October 1884.

Letters. A letter opens by addressing the editor (*nkosi mhleli … kaundifakele*, 'sir, editor … please print') and ends with a signature; 28 of 30 random detections were genuine letters (Table S5).

Framing. Embedding shift is a weak proxy for framing in Entman's sense: it also reflects sense, grammar and topic. We train fastText embeddings (Bojanowski et al., 2017) tuned for stability across seeds, since unstable embeddings create false shifts in small corpora (Antoniak & Mimno, 2018); this favours a narrow, grammar-heavy window (1), so we also report windows 2 and 5. A word's *profile shift* is $1 - r$ between its similarities to 500 common words in each paper (Hamilton et al., 2016b); *neighbour overlap* compares its ten nearest neighbours (Gonen et al., 2020); chance comes from shuffling issues (Dubossarsky et al., 2017). The directional test, the part aimed at framing, asks whether political words sit nearer religious or political anchors (Table S4). To read it, we count religious and legal words near *umhlaba*.

Tokenizers. We count subwords for XLM-R (Conneau et al., 2020), Serengeti (Adebara et al., 2023) and mBERT (Devlin et al., 2019) on modern news (Adelani et al., 2023), on the same news in old spelling (per word) and on our text (per character).

Results

H1: different things, but not more politics. Of ten political concepts, only parliament differs: Imvo uses it 3.3 times as often ($p = 0.018$ against matched sets; Fig. 1). Law, vote, rights, land and government do not differ beyond chance. Exploratory religion does: Isigidimi uses it 4.2 times as often ($p = 0.020$).

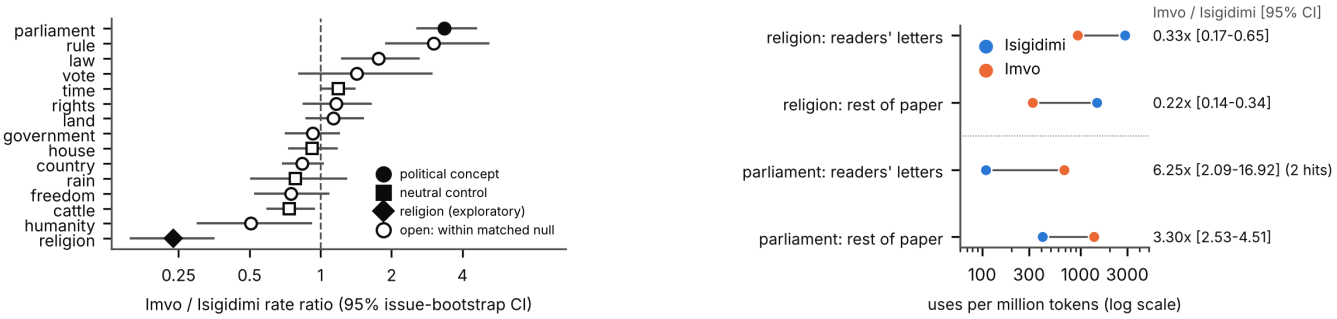


Figure 1: What the papers printed. Left: lmvo/Isigidimi rate ratio (95% CI; filled: $p < 0.05$ against matched sets, uncorrected). Right: the religious gap holds in readers' letters too.

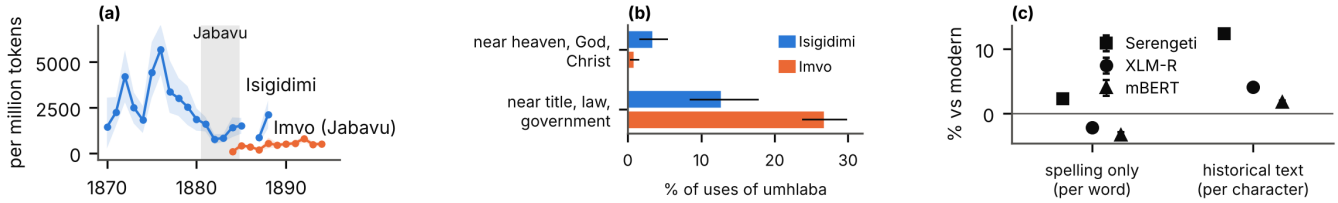


Figure 2: (a) Religious words per million tokens; grey: Jabavu edits Isigidimi, then lmvo; Gqoba edits Isigidimi from late 1884. (b) Uses of *umhlaba* near religious or legal words (95% CI). (c) Extra subwords against modern text (95% CIs smaller than markers).

Neither survives correction for 15 tests ($p < 0.003$). (CIs test whether rates differ; matched sets, whether a concept differs more than random words, which also differ between papers.) The religious gap holds in letters (lmvo/Isigidimi 0.33, CI 0.17–0.65) as in the rest (0.22). With Jabavu as editor of both, lmvo used religious words a third as often as Isigidimi (0.34, CI 0.24–0.48) and parliamentary words 1.7 times as often (1.2–2.5). Under the same control, Gqoba's Isigidimi used religious words 1.45 times as often as Jabavu's (1.06–1.96). Both span time: Isigidimi's religious rate had already fallen to 0.31 of its 1876–80 level by 1881–84 (Fig. 2a; Table S7).

H2: framing differences are weak and not specific. Word use differs overall (profile shift 0.348 vs 0.230 by chance), but no concept stands out: parliament reaches the 96th percentile of matched sets, the control *cattle* the 90th–99th (Fig. S1). Political words lean towards religious anchors in Isigidimi in all five settings (Δ +0.44 to +0.76 z-units; Bonferroni-significant in three; Table S2). But without *land* the lean is rarely significant ($p = 0.010$–0.256); the control *house* leans further (+0.84 to +1.51); dropping the anchor *endlu* ('in the house') leaves both leans in place (+0.62 and +1.04); and *umhlaba* sits near religious words in 3.4% of Isigidimi's uses (lmvo 0.9%), near legal or political words in 13% (lmvo 27%; Fig. 2b). A one-word concept must shift by 0.15 (1.645 matched-set SDs) to be detected, more than the overall gap (0.118).

H3: historical text costs more. Per character, our text needs 12.4%, 4.1% and 1.7% more subwords with Serengeti, XLM-R and mBERT; old spelling alone raises only Serengeti's cost (2.2% per word; Fig. 2c).

Discussion

How control worked (H1). What would have refuted control? Jabavu writing alike in both papers. He did not: leaving cut his paper's religious vocabulary to a third. But Gqoba's Isigidimi was more religious than Jabavu's, so the editor matters too; control is one cause among several. Our data cannot judge whether Jabavu was right to leave, but leaving brought less religion and only modestly more politics: Isigidimi already reported on parliament under him. Control also reached beyond editors: Isigidimi's letter-writers used religious words three times as often as lmvo's, so the papers drew on, or chose, different writers. One wrote that *ilizwi alizanga ukuba silipate, lize ukuba lisipate* ('the Word did not come for us to carry it; it came to carry us'; Isigidimi, 1 Nov. 1884, our gloss).

What the embeddings see (H2). The framing signal looks like a difference in meaning, not slant: Isigidimi more often uses *umhlaba* for the earth of creation, lmvo for land under title and law, which alone would place the word differently in each model. The detection floor turns this null into a bound: large framing differences are ruled out, small ones are not.

Responsible NLP (H3). The papers' history also reaches today's tools: old spelling penalises only the African-language model, perhaps because Serengeti's vocabulary has twice XLM-R's share of *th*/*kh*/*ph* pieces (1.9% vs 0.9%); this is a one-model hypothesis. Normalising a working copy is reasonable, but it must not replace the source: the mapping is lossy (old *t* may be modern *t* or *th*). Our results describe two papers, not isiXhosa speakers; reading them culturally without speaker review would be extractive (Bird, 2020).

Limitations and conclusion. Two papers, one window, a missing year, time-bound editor contrasts, a heuristic letter split, a news-domain mismatch, unreviewed stems (*rulumente* is 'government' here, 'parliament' in Schoots et al., 2023a, p. 62). So control, alongside the editor, shaped what these papers printed, down to their letter-writers; whether it shaped political language lies below our detection floor.

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Statement on the use of generative AI (Faculty of Science AI Ethics Statement)

Generative AI (Claude, by Anthropic, used through the Claude Code tool) helped to write the analysis code (data preparation, embedding experiments, statistics, figure scripts), to draft and edit the text and LaTeX source, and to fill in the checklist below from the course template. Generative AI was also used to review drafts and suggest revisions; suggested changes were checked against the code outputs and the cited sources before being kept. All numbers in the paper are produced by the submitted code and were read from its output files. The authors take full responsibility for all code and text submitted, including the accuracy of every claim and citation.

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    Justification: No crowdsourcing or human-subjects research was conducted. A first-language isiXhosa speaker is to be consulted as an expert adviser to check our interpretations; their judgments are not reported as data.

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Supplementary material

S1. Concepts, stems and the word forms they match (1 Nov 1884–1888, both papers)

Stems are matched as substrings of surface forms; following Schoots (2023b) we inspected forms for false positives (our first *law* stem also matched *inteto*, speech, and was dropped) but did not hand-filter them, so run-together forms (e.g. *rulumenteningomsebenzi*) and missed variants remain. All stems, forms and glosses await review by a first-language isiXhosa speaker. Political concepts were fixed before testing; religion was suggested by the classifier and is exploratory.

Concept	Type	Stems	Most frequent matched forms (count; number of distinct forms)
parliament	political	palamente	palamente (1754), ipalamente (47), palamenteni (22), epalamente (14), bapalamente (1), nepalamente (1), yepalamente (1); 11 forms
vote	political	voti	ivoti (301), voti (217), evotini (136), abavoti (98), ngevoti (55), levoti (22), nevoti (22); 115 forms
government	political	rulumente	rulumente (1882), rulumenteni (7), urulumente (5), serulumente (1), rulumenteningomsebenzi (1), zikarulumente (1), rulumenteayiko (1); 8 forms
rule	political	mbuso	zombuso (169), umbuso (76), mbuso (60), yombuso (42), kombuso (37), lombuso (28), kulombuso (23); 43 forms
law	political	mteto	umteto (724), lomteto (475), mteto (406), ngomteto (167), ngumteto (94), komteto (76), nomteto (76); 82 forms
rights	political	lungelo	amalungelo (315), ilungelo (288), lungelo (113), nelungelo (54), namalungelo (50), lilungelo (39), elilungelo (37); 115 forms
country	political	lizwe	lizwe (646), ilizwe (292), kwelilizwe (201), elilizwe (101), elizwe (96), belilizwe (76), yelilizwe (52); 78 forms
land	political	mhlaba	umhlaba (836), mhlaba (208), lomhlaba (156), nomhlaba (105), komhlaba (99), somhlaba (95), yomhlaba (94); 135 forms
freedom	political	kululek	inkululeko (27), kukululekile (24), ukululekile (13), ngenkululeko (10), abakulekileyo (8), nkululeko (8), nenkululeko (7); 92 forms
humanity	political	buntu	ubuntu (45), yobuntu (14), nobuntu (8), sobuntu (8), buntu (7), lobuntu (7), zobuntu (6); 29 forms
time	neutral	xesha	ixesha (787), ngexesha (364), xesha (298), amaxesha (243), lixesha (191), ngamaxesha (149), zamaxesha (114); 207 forms
house	neutral	ndlu	indlu (719), izindlu (328), kwindlu (276), ndlu (234), yendlu (227), ngendlu (133), nendlu (130); 193 forms
rain	neutral	mvula	imvula (267), mvula (31), yemvula (23), ezimvula (17), lemvula (16), yimvula (14), zimvula (10); 45 forms
cattle	neutral	nkomo	inkomo (555), zenkomo (258), nkomo (193), yenkomo (93), nenkomo (75), ngenkomo (35), lenkomo (33); 79 forms
religion	exploratory	tixo, kristu	tixo (684), kristu (207), makristu (7), kristukazi (7), mkristu (3), amakristu (2), lobukristu (1); 16 forms

S2. Secondary framing tests across settings

Percentile of the observed shift among 2000 frequency-matched word sets, and one-sided p (uncorrected). P+V = *palamente* + *voti*; P+V+R adds *rulumente* (uncertain meaning). Directional Δ: Isigidimi minus Imvo, religious minus political similarity (in z-score units), political concepts, two-sided p against matched sets; the last columns give the control *house*. Three settings survive Bonferroni over five ($p < 0.01$): window 1, window 2, and window 2 with forms joined. Joining partly disjunctive forms (*uku ba*) leaves the global profile gap unchanged. Matched sets are re-drawn for each test; without *land* the pooled set is smaller, so lower power may contribute to the higher p.

Setting	P+V profile	P+V Jaccard	P+V+R profile	P+V+R Jaccard	Δ	Δ p	p w/o land	house Δ	house p
window 1 (tuned)	92 (p=0.083)	96 (p=0.039)	92 (p=0.077)	99 (p=0.007)	+0.68	<0.001	0.010	+1.08	<0.001
window 1, forms joined	99 (p=0.010)	95 (p=0.053)	100 (p=0.001)	100 (p=0.002)	+0.44	0.016	0.088	+1.15	<0.001
window 2	86 (p=0.139)	94 (p=0.061)	90 (p=0.096)	99 (p=0.010)	+0.76	<0.001	0.045	+1.34	<0.001
window 2, forms joined	91 (p=0.094)	98 (p=0.023)	99 (p=0.011)	100 (p=0.002)	+0.58	0.009	0.064	+1.51	<0.001
window 5	62 (p=0.382)	98 (p=0.016)	81 (p=0.189)	100 (p=0.002)	+0.66	0.015	0.256	+0.84	0.061

S3. Era drift: does a concept's rate move across eras within one paper?

Per-million-token rates and ratios (later/earlier, or Imvo/Isigidimi) with issue-bootstrap 95% CIs.

Concept	Comparison	First	Second	Ratio (95% CI)
parliament	Isigidimi: later / earlier era	214	394	1.84 (0.96–4.98)
parliament	Imvo: later / earlier era	1320	758	0.57 (0.50–0.66)
parliament	Imvo 1889-94 / Isigidimi 1876-83 (held-out)	214	758	3.54 (1.98–9.58)
government	Isigidimi: later / earlier era	1667	1088	0.65 (0.50–0.85)
government	Imvo: later / earlier era	1210	452	0.37 (0.31–0.45)
government	Imvo 1889-94 / Isigidimi 1876-83 (held-out)	1667	452	0.27 (0.22–0.34)
vote	Isigidimi: later / earlier era	72	614	8.55 (3.51–18.94)
vote	Imvo: later / earlier era	799	921	1.15 (0.88–1.51)
vote	Imvo 1889-94 / Isigidimi 1876-83 (held-out)	72	921	12.82 (7.85–25.92)
religion	Isigidimi: later / earlier era	2466	1556	0.63 (0.46–0.84)
religion	Imvo: later / earlier era	362	547	1.51 (1.15–2.03)
religion	Imvo 1889-94 / Isigidimi 1876-83 (held-out)	2466	547	0.22 (0.18–0.28)

S4. Anchors for the directional test

Anchors are the 15 top-PMI neighbours of each seed pair in held-out text (Isigidimi 1876-83 + Imvo 1889-94), frozen before testing. Religious (15 words; seeds *tixo*, *kristu*): *sikelela*, *sindisa*, *ukumkanikazi*, *inkosazana*, *buka*, *oyingcwele*, *lilizwi*, *msindisi*, *nelizwi*, *kwelizwi*, *wanga*, *lika*, *yesu*, *izono*, *yehova*. Political (15 words; seeds *palamente*, *voti*): *emqulwini*, *wonyulo*, *lonyulo*, *elugqatsweni*, *eziqingata*, *lokunyula*, *kwesase*, *lokuvota*, *endlu*, *kwamagama*, *ukumela*, *izayo*, *ngalomteto*, *nawupina*, *kwabase*. Seed words cannot themselves be tested (Fig. S1). Political anchors include *endlu* ('in the house'), which might have favoured the neutral control *house*; re-running without *endlu* leaves both the political lean and *house*'s lean in place (outputs/framing_matched_tests_noendlu.csv), and *ngalomteto*, which contains the *law* stem. Glosses are unverified: two religious anchors (*ukumkanikazi*, *inkosazana*) may reflect royal rather than religious register, and several anchors on both sides (*lika*, *buka*; *nawupina*, *kwabase*, *izayo*) may be grammatical rather than topical, consistent with narrow-window PMI capturing grammar. All await speaker review.

S5. Readers' letters versus the rest of each paper

Letters are detected by src/12_letters.py: a letter opens by addressing the editor (vocative *mhleli* or *mcokeli*, not *u/ku/ngu mhleli*, which refer to him) or by asking for insertion (*ndifakele*, *kaundifakele*), and ends at the signature (a run of very short lines). A hand check of 30 random detections found 28 genuine letters; the errors were usifake umkala (horse advert: 'put a bit on it'); no mhleli wepepa lama bhulu ('and the editor of the Boer paper'). Recall was not measured. Imvo is restricted to the months in which Isigidimi has text; CIs from 4000 issue resamples; rates are not tested against matched sets. Hits = concept uses.

Part	Concept	Isig. tokens	Isig. hits	Imvo tokens	Imvo hits	Imvo/Isig.	95% CI
letters	parliament	18,344	2	70,475	48	6.25	2.09–16.92
letters	religion	18,344	52	70,475	66	0.33	0.17–0.65
letters	vote	18,344	4	70,475	58	3.77	1.04–18.93
letters	government	18,344	13	70,475	115	2.30	1.14–7.18
rest of paper	parliament	268,319	111	936,998	1280	3.30	2.53–4.51
rest of paper	religion	268,319	394	936,998	306	0.22	0.14–0.34
rest of paper	vote	268,319	172	936,998	821	1.37	0.79–2.83
rest of paper	government	268,319	299	936,998	902	0.86	0.67–1.13

S6. Which sense of *umhlaba*?

For every use of the land stem (*mhlaba*) we look at the 10 tokens either side. Religious cues: *izulu*, *lizulu*, *nezulu*, and words containing *zulwini*, *tixo*, *kristu*, *yesu*, *msindisi*, *ngcwele* (bare *zulu* is excluded: *kwa zulu* is Zululand). Property/political cues: words containing *taitile*, *mteto*, *rulumente*, *palamente*, *mantyi*, *fama*, *voti*, *nyulo*, *rafu*, *lokishi*. Most uses have neither cue. Example lines for a speaker to check are in outputs/land_kwic.md.

Paper	Cue	Uses	Share	95% CI
Imvo	religious	1408	0.9%	0.4–1.4%
Imvo	property/political	1408	26.8%	23.8–29.7%
Isigidimi	religious	353	3.4%	1.7–5.3%
Isigidimi	property/political	353	12.7%	8.5–17.7%

S7. Same editor, different control; same control, different editor

Cells (editors after Schoots, 2023b, p. 71): Jabavu edits Isigidimi (Jan 1881–Oct 1884); Jabavu edits Imvo (Nov 1884–1888); Gqoba edits Isigidimi (Nov 1884–1888); earlier editors of Isigidimi (1876–80). Ratios of rates per million tokens; 95% CIs from 4000 issue resamples (src/15_editor_control.py). Every contrast is also a contrast in time.

Concept	Jabavu: Imvo / Isigidimi ratio	Jabavu: Imvo / Isigidimi 95% CI	Isigidimi: Gqoba / Jabavu ratio	Isigidimi: Gqoba / Jabavu 95% CI	Isigidimi: 1881–84 / 1876–80 ratio	Isigidimi: 1881–84 / 1876–80 95% CI
parliament	1.69	1.23–2.54	0.50	0.33–0.79	49.86	14.75–400.26
vote	3.07	1.98–5.31	2.36	1.06–4.56	11.63	4.31–105.38
government	0.85	0.65–1.11	0.77	0.56–1.06	0.88	0.65–1.19
rule	19.47	9.28–69.57	8.28	3.60–30.48	0.38	0.09–1.33
law	1.36	1.08–1.72	0.80	0.55–1.16	1.31	0.97–1.76
rights	0.93	0.75–1.16	0.82	0.58–1.13	2.91	2.09–4.12
country	1.08	0.92–1.28	1.13	0.91–1.42	0.74	0.59–0.92
land	1.10	0.91–1.34	0.95	0.69–1.28	0.94	0.76–1.16
freedom	0.68	0.51–0.92	0.95	0.64–1.38	1.52	1.01–2.40
humanity	0.97	0.58–1.87	1.88	0.96–3.89	0.97	0.46–2.00
religion	0.34	0.24–0.48	1.45	1.06–1.96	0.31	0.23–0.41

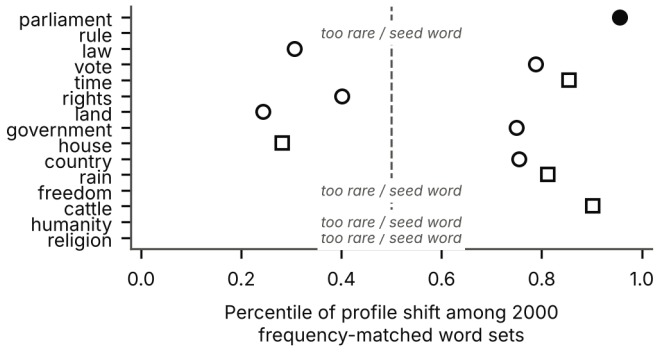


Figure S1: Profile-shift percentile of each concept among matched sets (markers as in Fig. 1, left); 'too rare' = too few occurrences, 'seed word' = anchor source, untestable.

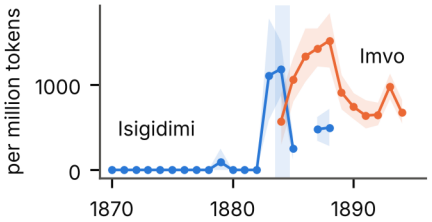


Figure S2: Parliamentary vocabulary per million tokens; it enters Isigidimi in 1883 (light blue: twice-monthly issues, Schoots et al., 2023a, p. 59).